acquired by India and featured in the parade. It was also evident in the two leaders' declaration that a closer US-India partnership was not just important for their countries but "indispensable" for the peace, prosperity, and stability of the Indo-Pacific. But left unsaid and unseen was a crucial factor that had been driving this partnership: China.

In recent years, as China has continued to rise as an economic, political, and military power, the US and India have been increasingly interested in developing a strategic relationship in response. Most have seen this as a relatively recent framework for building US-India relations after five decades of viewing the bilateral relationship either through a US-India-Pakistan lens or a US-India-Soviet one. For example, during the 2000 presidential election campaign, Condoleezza Rice argued that American foreign policy should move beyond the India-Pakistan conceptualization, emphasizing that the US "should pay closer attention to India's role in the regional balance" in Asia given China's rise.[3]

However, this strategic framework is not just a recent one. It echoes the framing from the first half of the Cold War, when the US in no small part viewed India through a China prism. The "loss" of China in 1949 had *Time* label India as the "anchor for Asia"[4] and the *New York Times* emphasize that the US had a stake in India because it was "potentially a great counterweight to China." The concept of a "fateful race" between the two Asian giants took hold,[5] with the Eisenhower administration noting in its 1957 statement of policy on South Asia that "the outcome of the competition between Communist China and India as to which can best satisfy the aspirations of peoples for economic improvement, will have a profound effect throughout Asia and Africa."[6] Consequently, the US needed to help India win the race—one of the few issues on which 1960 presidential contenders Senator John F. Kennedy and Vice President Richard Nixon agreed. This view endured through the Kennedy and Johnson administrations and then dissipated with Nixon's 1971 rapprochement with China, only to reappear three decades later in the George W. Bush administration.

Even in India the China and US relationships were not treated in a stovepiped fashion. Indian policymakers, for example, used American concerns about China turning communist to elicit aid from the US. But they, too, bought into the idea of a development race and worried about the